

CoARA Actions by FWO

September 25th 2024

1. Introduction

The Research Foundation Flanders (FWO) became a member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) and signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment in 2022. As part of that agreement FWO has designed an action plan on its implementation of the Core Commitments. In this action plan FWO describes its actions now and in the future in order to reform the research assessment in line with the agreement and CoARA.

2. FWO's way through an evolving research landscape

FWO is the largest funder in Flanders (Belgium) of fundamental and strategic research, as well as research infrastructure, mobility and some smaller kinds of support. It has very strong ties with the Flemish universities and research institutions and also entertains close contacts with European and global partners. Its role and partnerships always instigated and enabled a high degree of responsiveness to new evolutions in the research landscape.

In 2020, well before the creation of CoARA, it designed and started the implementation of reforms of its research assessment procedures and practices.

3. FWO's actions and plans with regard to reforming research assessment

FWO's broadening of research and researcher profiles of course dovetailed with international trends. Inspiring were initiatives such as the so-called San Francisco Declaration (Declaration on Research Assessments, DORA), the Leiden Manifesto, the Research Excellence Framework (REF) of the UK, the set-up of the research visitations in the Netherlands and in a similar way in Flanders (despite the still big role bibliometrics play in the funding of institutions there by the government), the Systemic Dutch approach by the Dutch research council, universities union and scientific academy (NWO, VSNU and KNAW), the European Research Council (ERC).

These sources of inspiration and thorough discussions with FWO's stakeholders led to the introduction of its so-called 'second axis', as distinguished from the 'first axis' of 'classical' output indicators like publications, citations, patents and the like. It stands for enriched criteria in evaluation procedures and the possibility of submitting a wider range of relevant activities and achievements in applications and reports on ongoing or completed research. The second axis concept mainly summarizes the efforts FWO is making with regard to an adaption of procedures and processes along the same lines as CoARA.

At the core of FWO's second axis approach stands the broadening of the evaluation of research and researchers. It is characterised by a balance between quantitative and qualitative parameters and methods, a proper use of those measures, taking into account the specificity of domains and research types, and also other than 'classical output' such as impact outside science, rendering services to society, a.o.

More specifically, FWO changed the proportion between candidate evaluation and project evaluation for the assessment of projects and fellowship applications. With regard to fellowships, for the calculation of the total score the share of the candidate score in the weighing was lowered from 60%

to 50% and the share of the score for the project part was increased from 40% to 50%, in order to decrease the impact of achievements in the past (i.e. the CV, publication list a.o.) in favour of potential for the future (the research proposal). That follows the distribution of 25% for the team and 75% for the research proposal in project applications that already existed before.

Other concrete adaptations to realise the broadening of our view on diverse research(ers) profiles include the introduction of a narrative, drawing attention to more than only 'classical' output and honouring an extensive definition of 'impact'. These conceptual adaptations are operationalised by means of a CV showing a broad set of activities, a section in the application form dedicated to career path and breaks with an explanation of their context, a publication list without explicit distinction made between Web of Science or similar types of publications and others, and a separate listing in the application form of the five main publications and/or achievements within the previous five years that are most relevant with regard to the newly proposed research.

More specifically, the 'research statement' as part of the CV is described as 'a narrative on the applicants' scientific career in past, present and future'. The explanation on this section points out that this statement should reflect in one narrative how the career evolved and will or can further develop, that it is meant as an opportunity to present a diverse range of activities and achievements in a context where FWO wishes to leave room for different profiles of academic researchers, and that diversity will also be taken into account during the evaluation of the application.

Not only is the second axis integrated in the documents regarding the application stage, but it is also taken into account for the evaluation of applications. FWO also communicates on different fora and wherever relevant about this new approach.

4. FWO and the 10 commitments of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

CoARA Commitments	Where FWO does stand	What FWO is planning
Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	The second axis, as explained above is integrated in all main funding programmes	An evaluation culture and way of appointing reviewers that fully take into account both axes are further developed. Instructing reviewers appropriately is constantly worked on, as well as training of reviewers. Measuring ex-post how effective the new evaluation policy is, is planned.
Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	FWO never enforced the use of metrics for evaluation, nor prohibited it. It always sought a balance between quantitative and qualitative indicators. An holistic approach of the evaluation by the external and internal peer reviewers is a key element.	The proper use of metrics and other quantitative indicators is part of the monitoring of the reformed evaluation policy. Further training of our panel members and external referees is an ongoing part of the process.
Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators		

Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	FWO never used that kind of lists, they are not even applicable to its procedures.	
Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	The staff of FWO takes this reform on as a core task among the other tasks dedicated to the organisation of calls and evaluation. IT-budgets are available to adjust the online applications forms and the online evaluation forms. Sufficient budget is available to compensate the experts for the time and effort they invest in the FWO-evaluation system.	Monitoring and improving the development of a new evaluation culture will remain a constant issue in the organisation and management of FWO's procedures.
Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	FWO's second axis approach refines existing criteria and provides for application forms and evaluation grids where a broad range of qualities can be shown and properly reviewed and scored. Sound processes require sound sets of mind, that we try to encourage and coach.	
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	FWO communicates to all target groups involved: researchers wanting to apply, reviewers, staff, other organisations, ... It offers guidance to applicants as well as to reviewers.	
Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	FWO is member of CoARA and engaged in its funders working group. Already before that it participated in Science Europe's working group research culture, that is still ongoing.	FWO will try to significantly contribute to the working groups and implement lessons learned from it.
Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the commitments		FWO will keep CoARA up to date about the evolution of its implementation of the commitments.
Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data	FWO follows up on science on science. FWO already shares data with the policy offices of	FWO wants to strengthen cooperation with researchers in this field as part of its policy plan.

openly available for evidence gathering and research	the host institutions and with researchers interested in research on gender, etc. and with the Flemish Research Portal : Zoeken FRIS onderzoeksportaal (researchportal.be)	
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